Anita Tsai

11/17/2023

Professor Cliff Lampe

SI 110

HelloTalk

Introduction:

In an increasingly globalized society, multilingualism has become both a valuable skill and a cultural bridge. Yet language learning requires significant time, motivation, and access to resources, which is not equally accessible for everyone. Self-guided learning requires exceptional discipline, while institutional education is often limited by financial barriers. As digital technology advances, more and more individuals have turned to online platforms that transform how languages are learned, shared, and practiced.

Among these tools, language learning applications stand out for their capacity to combine usability with pedagogy. The effectiveness of such applications often depends on their interaction design. Specifically, that is how user interfaces and experiences facilitate communication and engagement (Rogers, Sharp, and Preece). This paper examines HelloTalk, a language learning and social media platform, to evaluate how its design fosters community while simultaneously hindering certain aspects of structured learning.

HelloTalk differentiates itself from traditional learning apps through its interactive social environment and information economy. Its interface design promotes community participation and user-generated content, aligning with the principles of crowdsourcing and disintermediation. However, despite its success in encouraging interaction, the app's design of learning modules remains inconsistent and often fails to support vocabulary acquisition or systematic progression. This analysis explores how HelloTalk's community-driven features strengthen user engagement, while its design flaws impede deeper linguistic learning.

Background Information: What is HelloTalk?

HelloTalk explicitly states its value proposition as a "social media and language learning app" that enables users to "learn new languages, be exposed to new cultures, and make friends across the world" (HelloTalk.com). The application functions as a hybrid between a language exchange platform and a social network.

Similar to Duolingo, HelloTalk offers vocabulary practice through games and quizzes, but its difference lies in cultural exchange and community building. The app features three main functions: HelloTalk, Moments, and Connect. The HelloTalk function allows direct one-on-one communication between users, resembling private messaging features on social media platforms such as Instagram. Moments functions as a public feed where users can post updates, comment, and react to others' posts, incorporating a built-in translation feature to facilitate multilingual communication. Connect allows users to search for and establish new language partnerships. Collectively, these features position HelloTalk as both a communication tool and a learning environment, merging the experiential and social dimensions of language acquisition.

Analysis on building a community and fostering friendships:

HelloTalk's accessible interface and strong information economy foster a welcoming learning environment. *Information economics* concerns how information is produced and consumed—specifically, its value to users and the overall ecosystem. While information is costly to produce, it is inexpensive to reproduce (Shapiro and Varian 1). HelloTalk, like most social platforms, thrives on *user-generated content*, where posts, messages, and corrections continuously enrich the information flow.

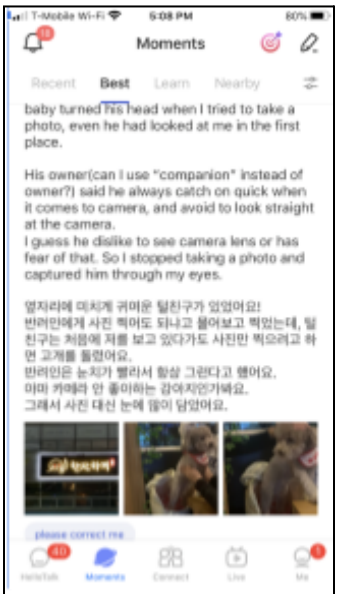

Figure 1: Sample Post someone made

A key design element supporting this ecosystem is *disintermediation*—the removal of intermediaries between users (Hayes). On HelloTalk, disintermediation enables learners to interact directly, offering feedback and corrections in real time. For example, users can post captions in their target language, which others can then edit to sound more natural (figure 1). The app thus mirrors broader social media dynamics, where open user participation increases engagement and content value (Parisi and Rega). The more users interact, the more valuable the platform becomes.

HelloTalk also encourages participation through an interface aligned with *Nielsen's Ten Usability Heuristics*. The posting process follows principles of consistency and standards and aesthetic minimalism (Nielsen). Icons and layouts mirror those of familiar social platforms, reducing cognitive load and simplifying participation. As seen in figure 2, the icons and steps to make a post adheres to the ten heuristics, thus making posting very easy and accessible for inexperienced and experienced users. The absence of unnecessary visual clutter makes posting quick and intuitive—promoting user engagement and sustaining the information economy.

Figure 2: Making a post

Another key component is *crowdsourcing*—the collection of knowledge and feedback from a large, diverse user base (Hargrave). Users derive both social and learning satisfaction from sharing knowledge (Kosonen et al.), which motivates continued participation. HelloTalk's randomized feed exposes users to diverse linguistic perspectives, allowing multiple users to offer alternative translations and expressions. This diversity enhances both the quality and quantity of linguistic knowledge available.

The platform's design also facilitates relationship-building. As shown in Figure 3, conversations between users (e.g., exchanging corrections and cultural notes) demonstrate how friendships form through language exchange. Features like *built-in translation* and *inline text editing* reduce friction, allowing users to correct each other's messages directly. This seamless communication promotes learning while strengthening community ties.

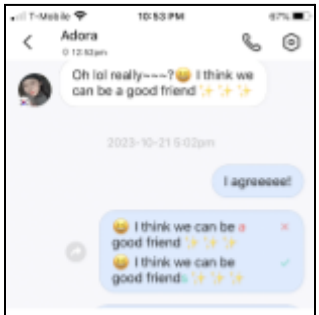

Figure 3: Making a New Friend

Over time, these relationships contribute to *platform stickiness*—users' tendency to remain on a platform rather than switch elsewhere. Similar to businesses that retain customers through strong relationships (Kitapci and Sahin), HelloTalk retains users through friendships and social connection. Since these interactions often rely on in-app translation and messaging tools, users remain engaged. In short, the more people who participate, the more valuable and fulfilling HelloTalk becomes.

Analysis – Learning hindered

Despite its strengths in community building, HelloTalk's design hinders structured language learning. Figure 4 illustrates that the app's landing page prioritizes chats and interactions, relegating learning tools to small icons at the top. Because conversation threads occupy more than two-thirds of the screen, users' attention is naturally drawn away from learning features. The lack of a dedicated learning tab—unlike *Moments* or *Connect*—makes these resources less visible. Research suggests that cluttered or hidden information reduces user engagement (Bialkova). Consequently, HelloTalk's design promotes social interaction but discourages sustained academic learning.

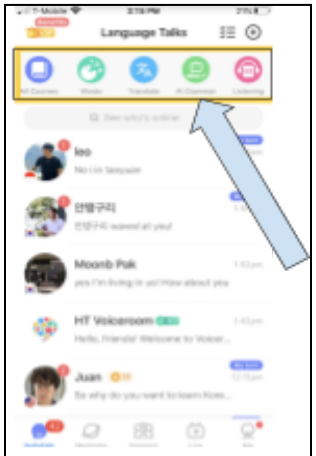

Figure 4: HelloTalk Page

Moreover, some visual elements fail to follow established design conventions, violating Nielsen's heuristics of consistency, flexibility, and aesthetic minimalism. In Figure 5, there are ten circles with different languages written on them. The circles here are an example of defiance from industry conventions where users who are new to the platform would not know where they're going by clicking on these circles. Moreover, the circles break the flexibility and minimalistic heuristics. Flexibility refers to having designs "that can cater to both inexperienced and experienced users" (Nielsen). Aesthetics and minimalist design refers to how the page is clean and includes only relevant information. Users on HelloTalk are usually only learning one language at once. While designers may have included multiple languages at once to increase user interest and thus engagement on the platform, having so many circles and languages at once actually works negatively where the interface becomes overly complicated and confusing.

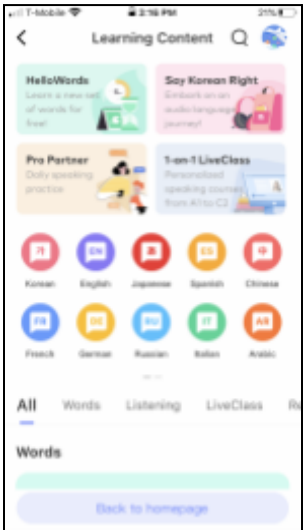

Figure 5: Learning icons

Similarly, boxes such as HelloWords, Say Korean Right, Pro Partner, and 1-on-1 LiveClass are either repetitive or function as advertisements rather than learning tools. The pink circle (with Korean written on it) is actually just a combination of the first green box (HelloWords) and pink box (Say Korean Right).

The redundancy makes it confusing for users to navigate and differentiate between the different learning features. The orange box for Pro Partner and purple box for 1-1 LiveClass are both ads that simply encourage users to pay more on top of the subscription base model. The unaesthetic and non-minimalistic design of the main page for the learning aspect of HelloTalk further reiterates the importance of adhering to the heuristics in order to facilitate a positive user experience. Self-learning a language in of itself is already difficult – having an app that makes navigating the pages even harder would only diminish the desire for users to learn.

Once users navigate into the learning modules, however, the interface improves considerably. Within the 5 minutes (or longer depending on how long you set it when setting up your account) of studying time everyday, there are multiple ways to learn vocabulary words. As shown in Figure 6, vocabulary content is clearly categorized by topic, and interactive exercises such as matching, quizzes, and fill-in-the-blank (Figure 7) promote active recall. These conventional, interactive methods—similar to those used by Duolingo or Quizlet—are effective for reinforcing vocabulary and pronunciation.

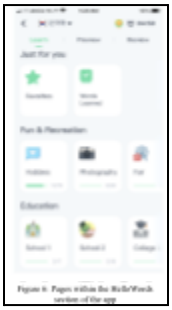

Figure 7: Different learning modes

Still, the lack of a prominent, guided progression (e.g., a “path” with spaced review and mastery thresholds) limits the modules’ long-term pedagogical value. Without stronger cues for sequencing and repetition, micro-practice risks becoming fragmented exposure rather than cumulative learning. This is not a failure of exercise design so much as a failure of navigation and signaling: the platform does not sufficiently scaffold *when* and *how* to return to material.

By quantifying a user’s impact on the platform, HelloTalk plays on the intrinsic competitiveness of humans – where they want to establish themselves and keep a positive reputation on the app. Furthermore, HelloTalk uses streaks to encourage engagement on the app. Streaks represent progress, and by achieving high streaks, it brings pride and achievement. Moreover, research has shown how streaks are seen as a product of our own work – where streaks are “susceptible to the endowment effect — the psychological perception by which we think anything in our possession is worth more than it actually is” (Heaney). However, the

Figure 8: Point systems

bigger the streak, the more users would also want to avoid losing it. The fear of losing the streaks can be "attributed to loss aversion, which is a cognitive bias where you feel the pain of loss twice as intensively than the equivalent pleasure of gain" (Make it Toolkit). Thus, by employing streaks in the app, users are motivated to stay consistent and log into the app to learn/review the languages they are learning. As a user, I did notice that while I was less motivated to study after losing my streaks, having friends on the app brought back my motivation to be on the app. This highlights the successful and innovative idea and concept of HelloTalk – where they foster a learning community to draw people in and hold them accountable for learning.

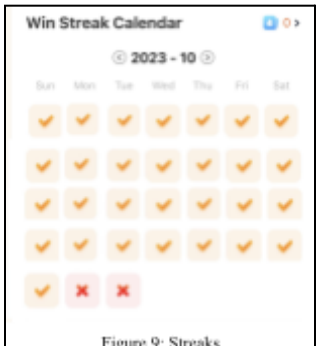

Figure 9: Streaks

Equity and Access: The Cost of "Premium" Learning

A major drawback lies in accessibility. Although HelloTalk's core community functions remain open to everyone, many of its more advanced features sit behind a paid subscription. This setup benefits those who can afford the premium plan while excluding users with tighter budgets. For an app that promotes itself as a platform for global language exchange, this imbalance undermines its inclusive goals. From an information-economics viewpoint, limiting advanced tools reduces both engagement and the overall quality of learning on the platform. With fewer learners reaching higher proficiency levels through structured study, the community loses valuable peer examples, feedback, and discussions. In short, when guided learning is scarce and locked behind a paywall, users tend to depend mainly on casual chats—fun for socializing, but far less effective for steady language growth.

Design Recommendations

To better balance social connection with educational depth, HelloTalk could implement several design adjustments grounded in Nielsen's usability heuristics. First, the app should present learning to the same level of visibility as its social features by adding a dedicated "Learning" tab alongside HelloTalk, Moments, and Connect. Within this tab, users could access their current lessons, scheduled reviews, and in-progress modules, allowing learning to feel like an integrated, ongoing process rather than an optional extra.

Another adjustment is to declutter and simplify the learning hub. The current interface, filled with overlapping tiles and multiple language circles, could be replaced by a single "Current Language" card

and a clean “Change Language” option. Redundant tiles—such as HelloWords and Say [Language] Right—should be consolidated, while promotional content should be visually separated from learning tools. This would help maintain aesthetic minimalism and reduce confusion for new users.

Finally, the app’s motivational systems could be reframed around growth rather than habit maintenance. Instead of rewarding any daily log-in, streaks could recognize mastery-based achievements, such as completing review sessions with high accuracy. Providing gentle “recovery” options, like a weekly forgiveness token, would reduce the frustration of lost progress while preserving accountability.

Limitations and Scope

This paper evaluates HelloTalk’s interface and learning design based on publicly available features and established usability frameworks. It does not attempt to measure learning outcomes experimentally or compare user performance quantitatively. The figures referenced throughout this paper illustrate design principles rather than serve as empirical data. Future research could build on this work by comparing user groups who engage only with HelloTalk’s social features against those who use both its social and structured learning tools. Such comparisons would help clarify how design changes influence vocabulary retention, conversational fluency, and long-term motivation in digital language learning environments.

Conclusion

Technology has democratized language learning, making it more accessible and engaging. However, HelloTalk’s strengths lie more in community building than in structured learning. Many premium features remain behind paywalls, limiting accessibility for budget-conscious users.

Ultimately, HelloTalk succeeds as a social platform but falls short as a comprehensive learning tool. Its intuitive social interface encourages engagement and fosters meaningful global connections. Yet its cluttered, unintuitive learning layout impedes vocabulary acquisition and progression. To truly balance its mission, HelloTalk should redesign its learning interface for greater visibility, coherence, and accessibility—ensuring that its powerful community features complement, rather than overshadow, the educational experience.

Works Cited

Babich, Nick. “Most Common UX Design Methods and Techniques.” *Medium*, UX Planet, 16 Oct. 2020, uxplanet.org/most-common-ux-design-methods-and-techniques-c9a9fdc25a1e.

Bialkova, Svetlana. “Standing out in the crowd: The effect of information clutter on consumer attention for front-of-pack nutrition labels.” *Science Direct*, vol. 41, 2013, pp. 65–74.

“Free Language Exchange: Language Partners.” *HelloTalk*, www.hellotalk.com/?lang=en. Accessed 15 Nov. 2023.

Hargrave, Marshall. “Crowdsourcing: Definition, How It Works, Types, and Examples.” *Investopedia*, Investopedia, 20 Nov. 2022, www.investopedia.com/terms/c/crowdsourcing.asp#:~:text=People%20involved%20in%20crowdsourcing%20sometimes,updated%20information%20to%20app%20users.

Hayes, Adam. “Disintermediation: Definition and Examples in Business & Finance.” *Investopedia*, Investopedia, 26 Apr. 2022, www.investopedia.com/terms/d/disintermediation.asp.

Heaney, Katie. “Why Breaking a Streak Feels so Awful.” *The Cut*, 5 Apr. 2019, www.thecut.com/2019/04/why-breaking-a-streak-feels-so-awful.html.

Nielsen , Jakob. “10 Usability Heuristics for User Interface Design.” *Nielsen Norman Group*, 24 Apr. 1994, www.nngroup.com/articles/ten-usability-heuristics/.

Parisi, Lorenza, and Rossella Rega. “Disintermediation in political communication: chance or missed opportunity?” *Academia*, 2011, pp. 1–13.

Sahin, Azize, and Hakan Kitapci. “Why Customers Stay: The Role of Switching Costs on the Satisfaction-Trust-Commitment Chain.” *Journal of Retailing*, vol. 73, no. 1, Dec. 2013, pp. 15–37.

Shapiro, Carl, and Hal R. Varian. “Chapter 1: Information Economy .” *Information Rules: A Strategic Guide to the Network Economy*, Harvard Business School Press, Boston, 2010, pp. 1–18.

Toolkit, Make it. “How to Design an Effective Streak with Behavioural Science.” *LinkedIn*, 21 Oct. 2022, www.linkedin.com/pulse/how-design-effective-streak-behavioural-science-make-it-toolkit/.